

- **Extended repayment:** You can use this plan if you owe more than \$30,000 in federal student loans. It gives you lower monthly payments over a twelve- to thirty-year period using either the standard or graduated repayment plan.
- **Loan consolidation:** This option allows you to combine all of your eligible student loans into one loan with one monthly payment.
- **Prepayment:** No matter what plan you have, there's always the option of prepaying all or part of your student loans at any time without penalty, which can greatly reduce your interest costs.

Forgiveness of Loans

In limited circumstances, some student loans can be forgiven without requiring repayment. You may be eligible to have part of your Stafford loan canceled if you obtained it on or after October 1, 1998, and you've taught full time for five years in a low-income school. You can obtain an application from your student loan lender.



ESSENTIAL

For more information on the loan forgiveness program for child-care providers, call 1-888-562-7002 or write to the Child Care Provider Loan Forgiveness Program, PO Box 4639, Utica, NY 13504. For information on the nursing forgiveness program, call the Nursing Education Loan Repayment Program toll-free at 1-877-464-4772.

The federal government recently instituted a new program whose purpose is to bring more highly qualified child-care providers into the profession and keep them longer. If you're eligible for this program, you may be able to wipe out part of your undergraduate Stafford loan. To be eligible you must have an associate's or bachelor's degree in early childhood education, must have worked for at least two years as a child-care provider in an eligible facility serving a low-income community, and must have taken out